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IGNIS WHITE PAPER



DECISION PLAYBOOK

Route to Market for Energy Developers

Strategy, revenue choices and agentic AI: how to choose, test and govern the route to market for each project.

November 2026 | 20 minute read

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Not legal, regulatory or investment advice. Facts checked 2 November 2026.

00 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The anchor route is a board decision. Take it on evidence, with a fallback in hand.

For CEOs, commercial leads and investment committees at energy developers. One job: to help you choose, test and govern the route to market for each project.

1 **What changed.** Rounds are larger and more contested, rules are tightening and corporate buyers are more selective.[1,7,9,12] In the UK, AR8 budgets are due on 19 November 2026 and sealed bids are indicatively due 3 to 9 December.[5,6]

2 **The decision.** One anchor route per project, one fallback with a dated trigger, and a floor price you will not go below.

3 **The evidence.** Each route convinces a different audience: a round's rules, a lender's price case, a buyer's credit team or a landowner and planner. Build the evidence once, with owners and dates.

4 **Agents and people.** Agents read rules, refresh scenarios and check that numbers match across submissions. Named people choose the route, set the floor and sign.

5 **What you keep.** A one-page route decision record per project, reused at every round, buyer process and board review.

ANALYSIS

£1/MWH ON A 60 MW SOLAR BID

about £0.6m

over a 20-year contract, in today's money

A ONE-YEAR SLIP

about £2.6m

of value lost if contracted revenue starts a year later

Assumptions: 11% capacity factor, 7% discount rate, AR7 solar price of £65.23/MWh.[1] Working on page 10.

Tools you can use on Monday

- Four-question anchor route tree
- Evidence checklist for each route
- Sensitivity method on your numbers
- Five approval gates with named roles
- One-page route decision record
- Ten-point readiness self-check

Inside

1 The decision and why it is hard 5
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3 Evidence each route needs 8
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FACT sourced, numbered ANALYSIS Ignis calculation from facts IGNIS VIEW our opinion

ASSUMPTION replace with your own

Sources on this page: [1] DESNZ, 10 Feb 2026. [5] Energy Voice. [6] Rendaq. [7] BNetzA. [9] EU 2025/1176. [12] Pexapark. Full list on page 19.

+ ROUTE TO MARKET IN BRIEF

What route to market is, how it is changing, and where agentic AI fits

WHAT IT IS

Route to market is how a project turns the power it will generate into revenue that lenders will finance. There are four main routes: a government-backed contract for difference (CfD) or state auction; a power purchase agreement (PPA) with a company or utility; a private wire to a nearby user; or merchant sales into the wholesale market, often hedged. The choice sets a project's revenue certainty, its financing terms and its timetable, so it is a board decision.

How it is changing

STRATEGY

FACT Rounds are bigger and the rules are moving: the UK's seventh CfD round awarded 14.7 GW,[1] and from 17 July 2027 new EU direct price support for wind and solar must take the form of two-way CfDs or equivalent.[10]

BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT

FACT Corporate buyers are more selective: disclosed European PPA volume fell to 13.1 GW in 2025 from 15.3 GW, while utilities raised their PPA offtake.[12] Buyer credit and timing now matter as much as price.

PROCUREMENT

FACT EU renewables auctions must now test bidders' ability to deliver on time.[9] Supplier prices, slots and evidence feed the bid itself, not only the lender pack.

Where agentic AI changes the work

Agents carry the groundwork

- Read round rules and notices into checklists
- Re-run scenarios the day a budget notice lands
- Check capacity, dates and price match across every submission and offer
- Draft board papers with every figure cited

People keep the decision

- Which route anchors each project, and the fallback
- The floor price and the walk-away
- The buyer relationship and the credit view
- The signature

IGNIS VIEW The split between agent groundwork and human decision is the Ignis method, applied in this playbook to one decision.

ABOUT THIS PLAYBOOK

Written for CEOs, commercial and business development leads and investment committees at energy developers. Ignis advises on strategy, business development, procurement and agentic AI transformation, from development to financial close.

Sources on this page: [1] DESNZ, 10 Feb 2026. [9] EU 2025/1176. [10] EU 2024/1747. [12] Pexapark. Full list on page 19.



PART ONE | CHOOSE

Name the decision before you price it

Which routes are really open to this project, what does each trade away, and what evidence would each audience need to see?

1	The decision and why it is hard	5
2	Options and trade-offs	6
3	Evidence each route needs	8

Photo: Dennis Schroeder, NREL, U.S. Department of Energy. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

01 THE DECISION AND WHY IT IS HARD

One anchor route, one fallback, one floor price, decided on purpose

The route to market sets a project's revenue certainty, its financing and its timetable. It is often chosen by the next deadline instead.

The UK dates your board will be held to

Date	What happens	Source
19 Nov 2026	AR8 budget notice and Notice of Auction (confirmed date)	[5,6]
3 to 9 Dec 2026	AR8 sealed bid window (indicative until the Notice of Auction)	[6]
15 to 17 Feb 2027	AR8 results (indicative)	[5,6]
4 to 17 Mar 2027	AR8 contracts signed and returned (indicative)	[6]
17 Jul 2027	New EU direct price support for new wind and solar must be two-way CfDs or equivalent	[10]

FACT

14.7 GW

awarded to 201 projects in the UK's seventh CfD round, the largest yet.[1]

FACT

5,250 MW

bid for 2,520 MW in Germany's 1 August 2026 onshore wind round.[7]

FACT

13.1 GW

of disclosed European PPAs in 2025, down from 15.3 GW in 2024.[12]

Why the decision is hard

The round decides on your evidence, once

FACT In AR8, solar, onshore and offshore wind bids may be viewed by government in anonymised form, and such applications get one sealed bid with no flexible bids.[3,4]

Budgets are set after the bids are seen

FACT Government will consider raising AR8 budgets only where unsuccessful bids represent strong value for money.[3]

Each route convinces a different audience

IGNIS VIEW Rules, lenders, a buyer's credit team or a planner. One evidence pack rarely serves all four without rework.

The rules keep moving

FACT EU auctions must apply non-price criteria, including the ability to deliver on time, to at least 30% of volume or 6 GW a year.[9]

Sources on this page: [1] DESNZ, 10 Feb 2026. [3] DESNZ, AR8 Pot and Price Notice, 6 Jul 2026. [4] DESNZ, AR8 Allocation Framework, rule 13.3 and Schedule 8. [5] Energy Voice, 15 Oct 2026. [6] Rendaq, 15 Oct 2026. [7] Bundesnetzagentur, 17 Sep 2026. [9] Regulation (EU) 2025/1176. [10] Regulation (EU) 2024/1747. [12] Pexapark, 27 Jan 2026.

02 OPTIONS AND TRADE-OFFS

Four routes, four different cases to make

ROUTE 1

CfD round or state auction

A government round awards long-term price support: CfD allocation rounds in the UK, CRE tenders in France, EEG auctions in Germany, and auctions in Spain and the Netherlands.

You convince: the round's rules, with a sealed price and the evidence to qualify.

ROUTE 2

Merchant

The project sells at market prices, often with hedges, short-term deals or a route-to-market partner. Common as the tail after a contract ends.

You convince: your board and lenders that the price case holds.

ROUTE 3

Corporate or utility PPA

A long-term contract with a company, utility or trader: physical, sleeved through a supplier, or virtual. Tenor, shape and credit decide its value.

You convince: one buyer's energy, legal and credit teams.

ROUTE 4

Private wire

A direct cable from the project to a nearby large user, usually alongside a grid connection. It needs its own consent, land rights and licence position.

You convince: one user, the landowners on the route and the planners.

FACT **Recent round results against their caps**

Round	Technology	Cleared	Cap	Src
UK AR7	Offshore wind, England and Wales	£91.20/MWh	£113	[2]
UK AR7	Floating offshore wind	£216.49/MWh	£271	[2]
UK AR7	Onshore wind	£72.24/MWh	£92	[1]
UK AR7	Solar	£65.23/MWh	£75	[1]
France, July 2026	Onshore wind, weighted average	€77.08/MWh	n/a	[8]
Germany, Aug 2026	Onshore wind, weighted average	4.79 ct/kWh	n/a	[7]

UK prices in 2024 money. AR8 keeps the AR7 caps: solar £75, onshore wind £92, offshore wind £113 and floating offshore wind £271 per MWh.[3]

Sources on this page: [1] DESNZ, 10 Feb 2026. [2] DESNZ, AR7 results, 14 Jan 2026. [3] DESNZ, AR8 Pot and Price Notice. [7] Bundesnetzagentur, 17 Sep 2026. [8] CRE deliberation 2026-129, 24 Jun 2026.

02 HOW THE ROUTES COMPARE

No route wins on every count

Each route trades certainty for upside or control. Choose the trade your lenders and your board will accept.

	CfD round	Merchant	Corporate PPA	Private wire
Price certainty	●●● Fixed strike price	●○○ Market price	●●○ Fixed or floored, per deal	●●○ Long contract, one buyer
Lender comfort	●●● Well understood	●○○ Needs hedges or more equity	●●○ Depends on buyer credit	●○○ Project on project risk
Upside you keep	●○○ Pays back above strike	●●● All of it	●●○ Shared, by structure	●●○ Shares network savings
Control of timing	●○○ Set by the round calendar	●●● Your own	●●○ Negotiated, can stall	●○○ Cable consent and land
Evidence to win	●●● Qualification and scoring	●●○ Lender price case	●●○ Buyer due diligence	●●● Consent, licence, metering
Onshore fit	●●● Main route in many markets	●●○ Often a later tail	●●● Strong where buyers exist	●●○ Only near large demand
Offshore fit	●●● Usual anchor	●○○ Rarely alone	●●○ Part of the mix	●○○ Rarely practical

IGNIS VIEW A qualitative framework, not data. Free to use with your team.

Does the round pay my bid or the clearing price?

FACT The UK CfD pays as clear: successful bids in a pot receive the clearing price, set by the highest successful bid and capped at the administrative strike price.[4] Germany's onshore wind auctions pay as bid: each winner receives its own bid.[7]

What that means for your price

ANALYSIS In a pay-as-clear round, bidding lower raises your chance of winning, not your income, so the work that matters is the floor. In a pay-as-bid round, the bid is the income, and every euro counts twice.

Sources on this page: [4] DESNZ, AR8 Allocation Framework, rule 19 (clearing price). [7] Bundesnetzagentur, 17 Sep 2026 (pay-as-bid, values between 4.49 and 4.98 ct/kWh).

03 EVIDENCE EACH ROUTE NEEDS

Build the evidence once, for the audience that will test it

Most route evidence is shared: land, consent, grid, yield and cost. What differs is who tests it and what they look for first.

Route	What the audience tests first	Evidence to hold, owned and dated	Where it goes stale
CfD round	Eligibility, the sealed price in 2024 money at or below the cap, and target dates inside the delivery year window[4]	Consent, grid offer and date, capacity, floor price workings, delivery evidence where scored[9]	Grid date moves; capex and yield refresh; new notice or framework
Merchant	Whether the price case survives a downside your lenders choose	Independent price curves, capture rates, hedging options, lender sizing cases	Each new curve release; negative price hours; cost of debt
Corporate or utility PPA	Buyer credit, tenor, shape and volume risk, termination and change in law	Generation profile, credit support offered, sleeving terms, term sheet history	Buyer appetite shifts; credit ratings; market prices since the offer
Private wire	Whether the cable can be consented and built, and the user's demand and credit	Cable route and land rights, consent path, licence position, demand profile, metering	Landowner positions; user's own plans; planning policy

IGNIS VIEW except where a source is cited. Check each item against the current rules for the round or market you are in.

The four evidence rules

1. Every number has a source, an owner and a date.
2. One version of capacity, dates and price across every submission.
3. Stale items are flagged before a gate, not found by the buyer.
4. Assumptions are labelled as assumptions in every board paper.

Where agents carry the load

Reading notices and frameworks into a checklist, flagging evidence older than its refresh date, and listing every place a number appears. People decide what counts as current and what the board sees.

Sources on this page: [4] DESNZ, AR8 Allocation Framework, rule 13.1 (sealed bids). [9] Regulation (EU) 2025/1176, article 6 (ability to deliver: permits, financial capability, technical feasibility, timetable).



PART TWO | TEST

Test the answer before the market does

What moves the value of each route, which route anchors the project, and what would make you switch to the fallback?

4	Scenario and sensitivity comparison	10
5	Anchor route and fallback route	11

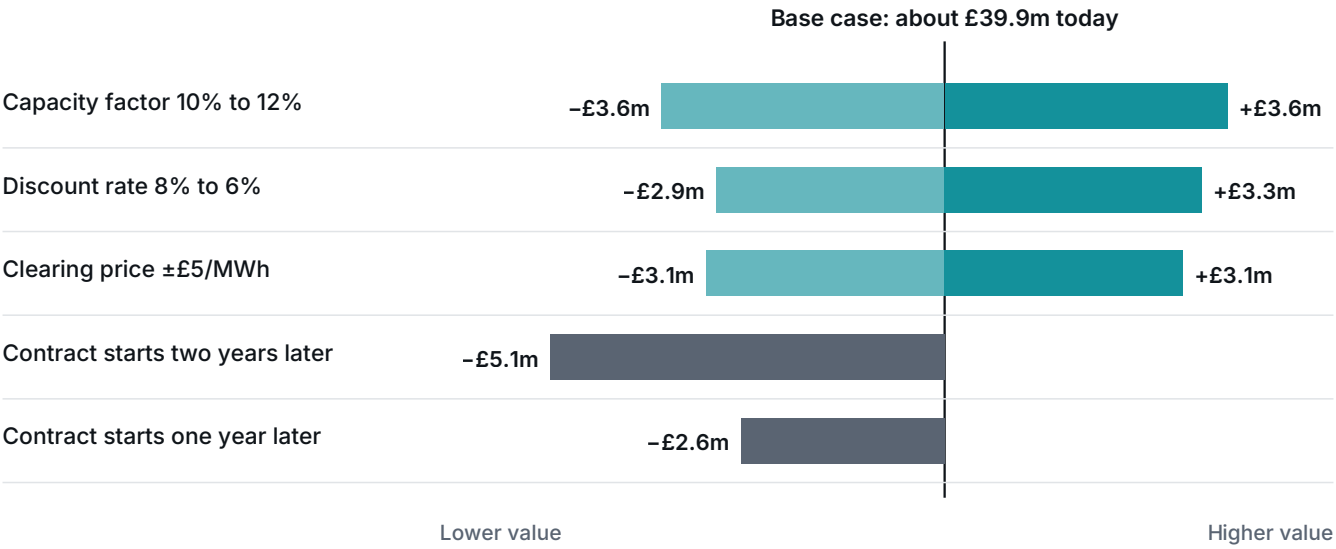
Photo: Dennis Schroeder, NREL, U.S. Department of Energy. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

04 SCENARIO AND SENSITIVITY COMPARISON

Find the two inputs that move the answer, then test them hard

Most route decisions turn on two or three inputs. A sensitivity chart shows which ones, so the team spends its effort there.

60 MW SOLAR: VALUE TODAY OF 20 YEARS OF CONTRACTED REVENUE, AND WHAT MOVES IT



ANALYSIS Ignis calculation. Revenue only, before costs, indexation and merchant tail.

Input	Value
Capacity	60 MW ASSUMPTION
Capacity factor	11% ASSUMPTION
Output	57,816 MWh a year
Price: AR7 solar[1]	£65.23/MWh FACT
Term[11]	20 years FACT
Discount rate	7% ASSUMPTION

Value a bid before you write it

Bid value = chance of winning × margin if you win − cost of bidding − chance of an error × cost of that error

IGNIS VIEW The last term is the one teams leave out: a delivery year the grid date cannot meet, or a PPA offer that contradicts the round bid. Cross-checks cut it more cheaply than extra drafting.

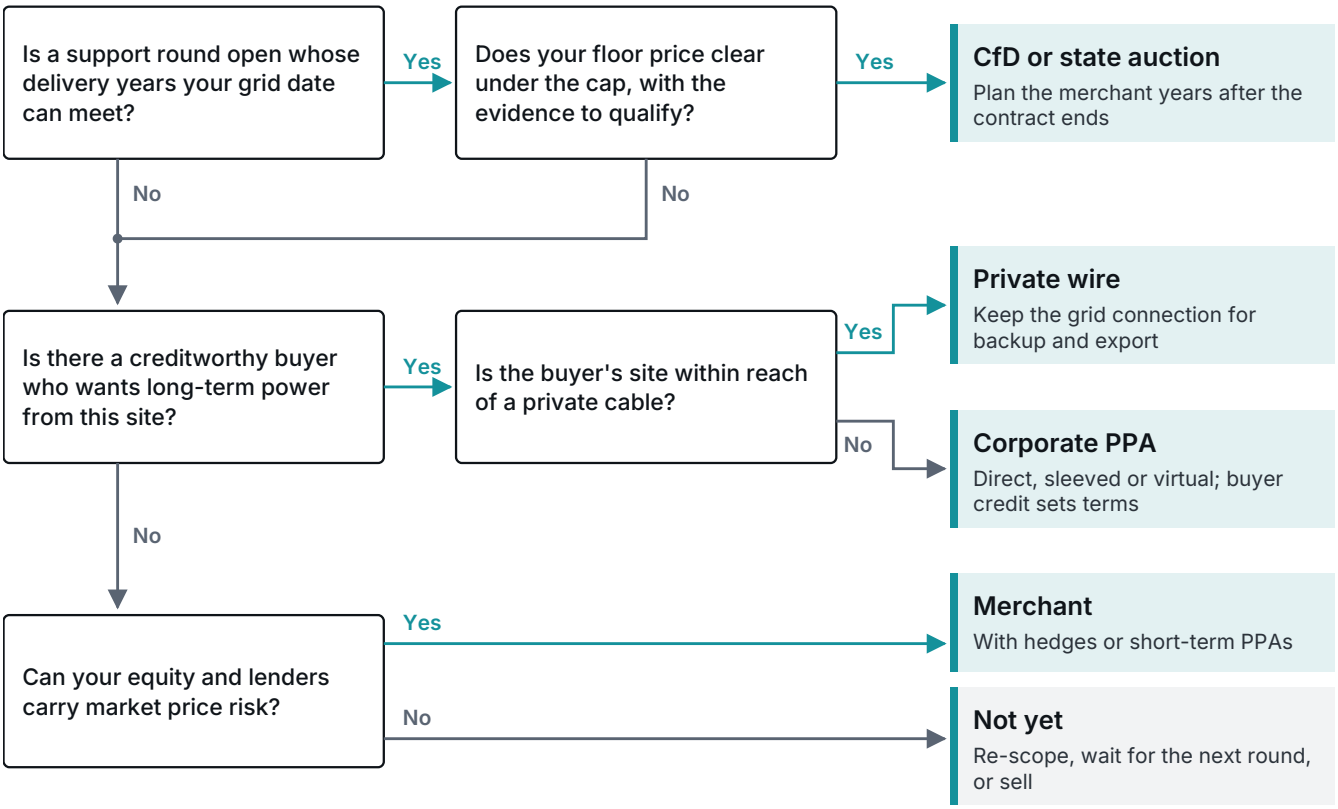
Run it on your own numbers: replace every assumption, add the route's own risks (buyer credit for a PPA, capture rate for merchant, cable consent for private wire) and keep the run with its inputs in the record.

Sources on this page: [1] DESNZ, 10 Feb 2026 (AR7 solar £65.23/MWh, 2024 prices). [11] DESNZ, AR7 government response, Jul 2025 (20-year CfDs). Method on page 19.

05 ANCHOR ROUTE AND FALLBACK ROUTE

Four questions find the anchor. A dated trigger keeps the fallback alive.

Ask the four questions for every project each year, and whenever a round, a buyer or a grid date changes.



IGNIS VIEW A framework, not data. Free to use with your team.

Set the fallback before the bid goes in

- **Name it:** usually the next branch down the tree.
- **Date the trigger:** for example, the round result or a budget notice that leaves your floor above the likely clearing range.
- **Keep it warm:** a live buyer conversation or a current price case, not a slide.

FACT **When a round under-delivers**

Spain's November 2022 auction offered 3,300 MW and awarded 45.5 MW.[13] Spain was still Europe's largest PPA market in 2025, at 3.9 GW.[12]

IGNIS VIEW Where teams slip: answering the first question from the round calendar instead of the grid date.

Sources on this page: [12] Pexapark, 27 Jan 2026. [13] BOE-A-2022-20540, 23 Nov 2022 (awards totalling 45,500 kW).



PART THREE | GOVERN

Decide it once, record it, reuse it

Who decides at each gate, how the bid or negotiation runs, and what the board signs and keeps for the next round.

6	Decision rights and approval gates	13
7	Bid, negotiation and buyer-readiness workflow	14
	Worked example: one project, one decision	15
8	The route decision record	17
9	Self-check and next step	18

Photo: Dennis Schroeder, NREL, U.S. Department of Energy. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons. Cropped.

06 DECISION RIGHTS AND APPROVAL GATES

Five gates, each with a named decider and a written output

The gates are where judgement is used. Everything before a gate is preparation, and preparation is where agents help.

Gate and trigger	Evidence the decision needs	Agent groundwork	Who decides, and what is recorded
1 Route screen Yearly, or a new round, buyer or grid date	Portfolio calendar, grid dates, routes open to each project	Calendar of rounds and buyer processes; digest of new rules	**Commercial director.** Routes in and out of scope, with reasons
2 Anchor and fallback After the screen	Evidence pack per route; scenarios and sensitivities	Scenario runs on linked inputs; evidence age report	**Investment committee.** Anchor, fallback, trigger date
3 Bid or no-bid, and floor Before the window opens	Current capex, yield and grid evidence; rules checklist	Model refresh; rules compliance check; first draft of the reason	**Board or delegate.** Go or no-go, floor price, signed reason
4 Submission or heads of terms Before anything leaves	One version of capacity, dates and price everywhere	Cross-check report across every live submission and offer	**Authorised signatory.** What was sent, to whom, on what basis
5 Result and switch Result or trigger date	Result, clearing data, buyer status	Debrief draft; trigger check against the record	**Commercial director.** Close the round or start the fallback

IGNIS VIEW Roles are examples. Use your own delegation of authority; the point is that every gate has one named owner.

Three rules for the gates

- No gate is passed without its written output.
- The decider sees the assumptions, labelled as such.
- Agents prepare and check; they never pass a gate.

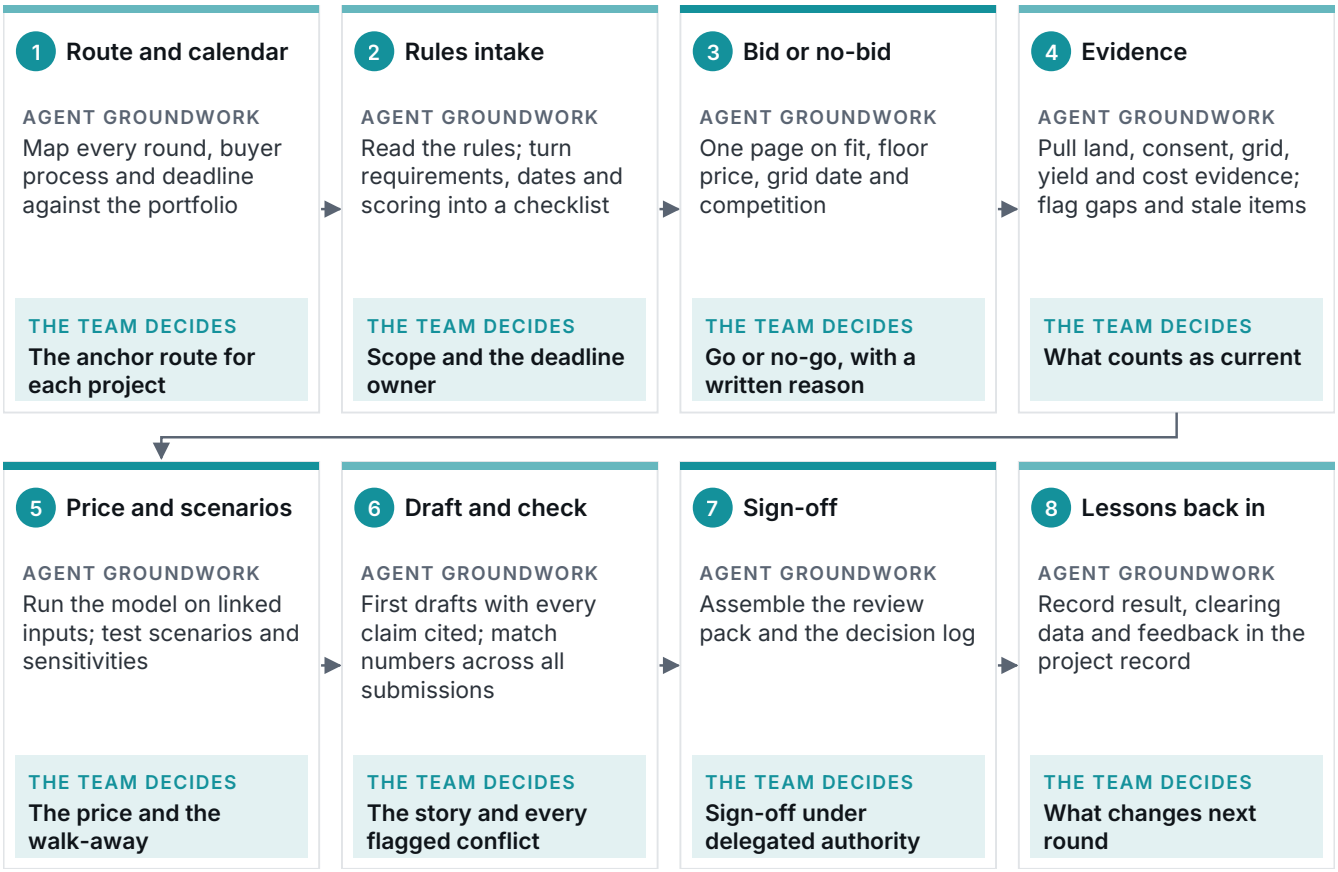
The test of a good gate

A new team member could read the record a year later and see what was decided, on what evidence, and by whom.

07 BID, NEGOTIATION AND BUYER-READINESS WORKFLOW

Eight steps from route choice to a signed bid or term sheet

The same sequence runs a sealed round bid, a PPA negotiation or a private wire offer. Agents carry the groundwork; the team decides at every step.



IGNIS VIEW A framework, not data.

Round bid

Readiness means a qualified application, a signed floor and one sealed price that matches every other document.

PPA negotiation

Readiness means a walk-away price, a credit view of the buyer and a mark-up position for each key term.

Private wire offer

Readiness means a consentable cable route, land positions and the user's demand and credit in writing.

THE WIDER OPERATING MODEL

This playbook applies the Ignis model to one decision. Why process comes first and data second, how agents, connectors and human gates fit together, build or buy, adoption and the 90-day path are covered once, in the flagship guide **Agentic Transformation for Energy Developers**: ignisleadership.com/resources/agentic-transformation-for-energy-developers

WE WORKED EXAMPLE: ONE PROJECT, ONE DECISION

COMPOSITE EXAMPLE, NOT A CLIENT

Project S60: a 60 MW solar site choosing between AR8, a PPA and a private wire

Fictional, built from situations common to UK solar developers. Project facts are assumptions; market facts are sourced.

Commercial pressure why now	The AR8 budget notice lands on 19 November 2026 and the sealed bid window is indicatively 3 to 9 December.[5,6] A utility has sent an indicative 10-year PPA offer. A food plant 4 km away has asked about a direct supply. ASSUMPTION
Decision and options considered	Which route anchors S60, which is the fallback, and the floor price. Options: **A** AR8 CfD with a merchant tail; **B** utility PPA plus merchant; **C** private wire for part of the output plus a CfD for the rest; **D** wait a year.
Evidence project facts and constraints	Consented; qualified for AR8; grid connection date inside the 2029/30 delivery year; capacity factor 11%; cable route to the plant crosses three landholdings with no agreements. ASSUMPTION
Evidence market	FACT AR7 solar cleared at £65.23/MWh against a £75 cap, and AR8 keeps the £75 cap.[1,3] Solar bids get one sealed bid and may be viewed by government.[3,4] Disclosed European PPA volume fell in 2025 while utilities raised their PPA offtake.[12]
Evidence assumptions and uncertainties	Floor price £62/MWh on current capex and yield; 7% discount rate. ASSUMPTION Unknown until 19 November: the pot 1 budget. Unknown until February: the clearing price.
Current workflow what goes wrong today	The bid team, the PPA origination lead and the private wire lead each hold their own capacity, dates and price. The floor price was last set in spring. The board paper is drafted in the final week.

The options at the route screen

Option	What it offers	What it needs	Verdict at the screen
A AR8 CfD, merchant tail	20 years of price certainty lenders know[11]	A floor that clears; one sealed bid	Anchor candidate
B Utility PPA, merchant	Timing in the team's hands	A credit view and a walk-away price	Fallback candidate
C Private wire and CfD	A direct buyer for part of the output	Cable consent, land rights, licence position	Parked: no land agreements
D Wait a year	Time to firm up the evidence	About £2.6m of value given up (page 10)	Rejected unless evidence fails

WE **WORKED EXAMPLE: ONE PROJECT, ONE DECISION**

Agent groundwork research and scenario updating	Read the AR8 notices and framework into a rules checklist. Re-run the scenarios on the day the budget notice lands. Check capacity, dates and price across the application, the PPA term sheet and the board paper, and list every conflict. Draft the board paper with each figure cited to the record.
Human authority judgement the team keeps	The floor price. Whether to keep the PPA talks open in parallel, and what to tell the buyer. The credit view of the utility. Whether the private wire is worth a landowner approach now.
Control checks	Every figure traces to a dated source in the record. Assumptions are labelled in the board paper. Nothing leaves the business without the signatory's approval. The scenario run is kept with its inputs.
Reusable output	A route decision record for S60, its evidence library with owners and dates, the floor price workings, and the PPA terms history.

BOARD DECISION AND RATIONALE

Anchor: AR8 CfD for the full 60 MW, one sealed bid at a floor of £62/MWh. **Fallback:** the utility PPA, kept warm until the AR8 result, with a trigger on the result or a budget notice that leaves the floor above the likely clearing range. **Private wire:** parked until the annual review. **Wait:** rejected.

Why: the CfD gives the longest price certainty lenders already understand, and the floor sits below the last solar clearing price. The PPA protects the timetable if the round does not clear for S60. The cable route has no land agreements yet.

What carries into the next round

- The result and clearing price against the floor
- Buyer feedback and the PPA terms reached
- Which evidence went stale, and when
- The two hand-offs that cost most time

What this example does not claim

It is not a client case and shows no results. The numbers are assumptions chosen to show the method; replace them with your own.

How the decision runs against the AR8 calendar ASSUMPTION internal dates

When	Step	Gate
Early November	Route screen and evidence age report	1 Route screen
Mid November	Committee sets anchor, fallback, trigger	2 Anchor and fallback
19 November	Budget notice published; scenarios re-run the same day[5,6]	Input to gate 3
Late November	Board signs the floor and the bid reason	3 Bid and floor
3 to 9 December	Sealed bid sent after the cross-check (indicative window)[6]	4 Submission
15 to 17 February	Result; fallback closed or started (indicative)[5,6]	5 Result and switch

Sources for the worked example: [1] DESNZ, 10 Feb 2026. [3] DESNZ, AR8 Pot and Price Notice. [4] DESNZ, AR8 Allocation Framework. [5] Energy Voice. [6] Rendaq. [11] DESNZ, AR7 government response. [12] Pexapark.

08 THE ROUTE DECISION RECORD

Route decision record

Project _____ Version ___ Date _____

Decision required and the date it is needed by	
Routes considered and why any were ruled out	
Anchor route	
Fallback route and its dated trigger	
Floor price or walk-away basis and date of inputs	
Key evidence source, owner and date for each item	
Assumptions labelled, with the range tested	
Sensitivities the two inputs that move the answer	
Risks and open questions	
Agent groundwork used what was prepared, and how it was checked	
Decision and rationale	
Decided by name, role and authority	
Review date or trigger	
Carried forward what the next round or buyer process reuses	

Free to copy and use with your team. Keep one record per project, versioned, in the same place as its evidence.

09 SELF-CHECK AND NEXT STEP

How ready is your route decision for AR8 and the round after it?

Tick what is true today, not what is planned.

- ☐ Each project has a named anchor route, reviewed in the last twelve months
- ☐ Each project has a named fallback with a dated trigger
- ☐ We hold one calendar of every round and buyer process across the portfolio
- ☐ Every bid has a signed bid or no-bid reason and a floor price
- ☐ The floor price reads current capex, yield and grid evidence
- ☐ We know which inputs move each route's value most
- ☐ Capacity, dates and price match across every live submission and offer
- ☐ Each gate has one named decider and a written output
- ☐ Assumptions are labelled in every board paper
- ☐ Results, clearing prices and buyer feedback go back into the record

Score. 0 to 3: start with the four questions and a route decision record per project. 4 to 7: fix the evidence ownership and the cross-checks, then add agents to the groundwork. 8 to 10: your route decisions are ready to scale across more rounds and buyers.

NEXT STEP

A commercial diagnosis on one live project

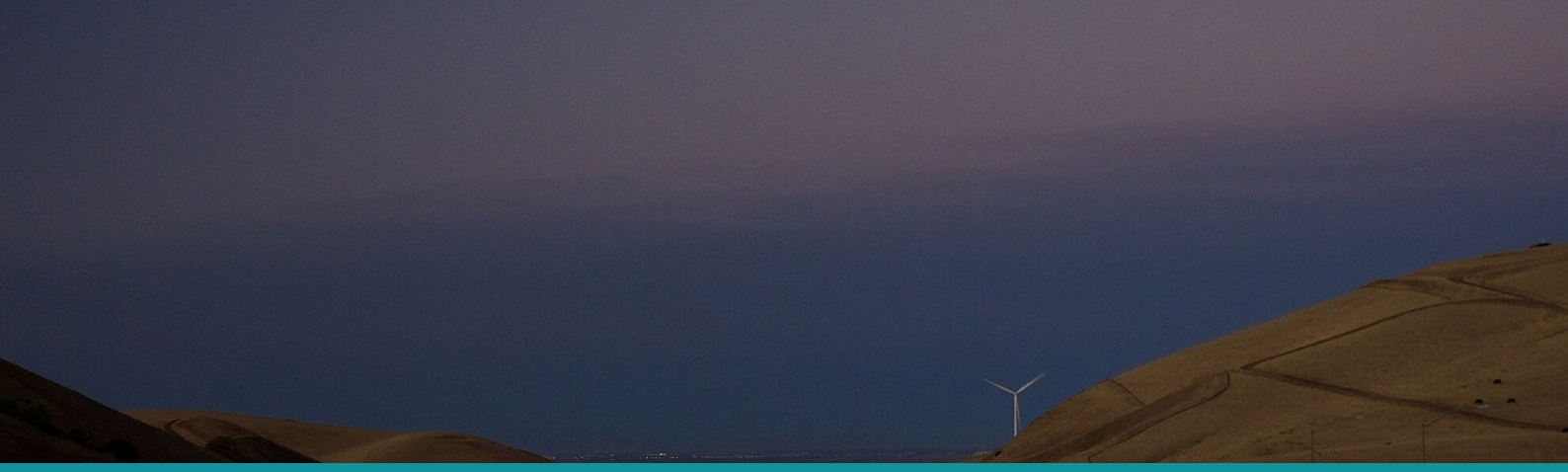
We take one project you are weighing between a round and a PPA. Together we test the anchor and fallback, the evidence behind them and the gates that approve them, and leave you with a first route decision record and the two fixes that matter most. Your team decides. Start at **ignisleadership.com/contact**

+ SOURCES AND METHOD

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Method. 60 MW × 8,760 hours × 11% = 57,816 MWh a year. Present values use a 20-year annuity at 7% (10.594). Revenue uses the AR7 solar clearing price as a proxy and ignores costs, indexation and merchant tail. A slip discounts the same stream by one or two more years. The capacity factor, discount rate and composite project facts are assumptions. AR8 dates after 19 November 2026 are indicative until the Notice of Auction. All sources checked on 2 November 2026.

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